

Refuse and reject

Teaching guide

Decline an action or turn down an offer.

Understand the distinction

Refuse can take to + verb: I refused to sign. It can also take an offer or request: refuse an invitation. Reject commonly takes a noun naming something not accepted: reject a proposal, reject an application.

Do not use reject to do for declining an action. Either verb can sound strong depending on context. Decline is often a courteous choice for an invitation. State a reason or an alternative when it helps the conversation, without inventing one.

Compare the patterns

ACTION

She refused to sign the form.

Refuse takes a to-infinitive.

PROPOSAL

They rejected the proposal.

Reject takes the proposal as its object.

INVITATION

Thank you, but I must decline.

A courteous way to turn down an invitation.

Read each example and notice how its form changes the meaning. Use these distinctions to choose your answers on the following pages.

Check your understanding

Circle one answer for each question. There is one correct choice among the options shown. Check the answer key after choosing.

1. Complete: He refused ___ answer.

A. from

B. for

C. to

2. Choose the correction: They rejected to meet us.

A. They refused meet us.

B. They rejected meeting to us.

C. They refused to meet us.

3. Can refuse take a noun?

A. No. Refuse must always take a to-infinitive.

B. Yes: refuse an invitation or refuse help.

C. Yes, but only the noun answer.

Choose the best response

Choose the response that fits the situation. Check both its meaning and its grammar.

4. You cannot attend an event and have given no reason. Which reply declines politely without inventing one?

- A. Thank you for inviting me. I look forward to joining you.
- B. Thank you for inviting me, but I cannot join because I am ill.
- C. Thank you for inviting me, but I cannot join you this time.

Review your choices

Use the answer explanations on the next page. If you chose a different answer, find the detail that makes it unsuitable and try the question again.

Practice online

The web lesson gives feedback for the option you select and lets you try again. No written response is required.

Answers and explanation

1. C. to

Use refuse to do something.

A: Use refused to answer, not refused from answer.

B: Refuse takes a to-infinitive for the action: refused to answer.

2. C. They refused to meet us.

Reject does not take this to-infinitive pattern.

A: Refuse needs to before the infinitive: refused to meet.

B: This is not a correct replacement for the stated decision not to meet.

3. B. Yes: refuse an invitation or refuse help.

Its patterns are broader than refuse to do.

A: Refuse can take a noun, such as help or an invitation.

C: Many nouns can follow refuse, including help and an invitation.

4. C. Thank you for inviting me, but I cannot join you this time.

This declines courteously without adding an unsupported explanation.

A: This accepts the invitation rather than declining.

B: The prompt does not establish illness; the reply invents a reason.

Continue learning

Web lesson and related topics: englishladder.com/grammar-concepts/concept-41.html

A practical teaching sequence

1. Notice (2 minutes)

Read the comparison examples with the learners. Point out the meaning and form that distinguish each pattern.

2. Choose (4 minutes)

Learners select one option for each of the three checks. Keep the answer key covered. Use the selected option's explanation rather than presenting a generic model as feedback.

3. Apply (5 minutes)

You cannot attend an event and have given no reason. Which reply declines politely without inventing one?

Learners choose the response that fits this situation. All responses in this activity are multiple choice; do not replace the choices with a written-answer task.

4. Review (3 minutes)

Compare selected options with the key. Use the option-specific notes to explain why a distractor does not fit. Let learners change their selection and try again.

Scope of the answer key

Each question has one correct option among the choices shown. This does not mean that every other way to express the idea is wrong. Preserve the qualifications in the teaching notes.

Feedback criteria

Check both grammatical form and the stated situation. A correct option answers this question; four correct choices do not certify a learner's overall proficiency.